Anything in the name of love

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Anything in the name of love

by NightFox9

Summary

Simple task. Nothing suspicious. Until things went wrong and one of the guardians was kidnapped.

Peter loosing his mind while Gamora was bleeding to death.

>Included a new photo edit of Gamora!

Notes

Recommend songs while reading:

'Yellow Flicker Beat' by Lorde.

'No Light, No Light' by Florence +The Machine

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Have fun!

'Simple' is an Illusion

I decided to post one of my edits as well: This is how I picture Gamora in the first chapter.



It was a simple task. The guardians were hired by some known millionaire as an additional security at his party. And what do you do when you have a death threat? You are organizing a party with over five thousand invited guests, of course! *What a bullshit*, Peter thought.

Not that it was any of his business, especially considering the huge amount of units they would get paid for literally doing nothing.

They were all distributed in a huge place. And by huge is meant huge. Four spacious rooms, two of which were ballrooms and a garden large enough to land a ship like the Milano there.

Rocket and Groot were together in the first district, which had a good view of what was happening at the entrance. Their job was to check for suspicious types and scan the faces of the newcomers.

Mantis was in the next room with open access to Drax's, which was full of loud dance music.

As much as Peter wanted to be among the dancing people and enjoy the rhythm of the dance steps, he was positioned in the hall, where more serious events took place, so to speak.

He and Gamora were the direct guards of the millionaire and his family. His wife, pretending to be kind to everyone, and his daughter, frowning that she couldn't go dancing with the others. Peter only heard that she had seen a sweet boy and the rest he ignored. He tried to focus on the people around him, sticking to the mission, but somehow his brain flew in other directions. Concentration was not his thing. But that's why Gamora was with him.

He looked at her. Her eyes scanned the crowd. Her focused face was warmed by the orange lights around them.

"Nothing will happen if you blink from time to time, you know."

She didn't look at him, but answered. "It will if you blink at the same time." Peter chuckled. If it was anyone else, he would hardly have realized that it was a joke, but he was already able to capture her sarcasm. And he was genuinely amused when she, too, indulged in a joke.

“Was that *a joke* I heard?” He said, acting surprisingly amused as he didn't take his eyes off her.

"No, that was your imagination playing tricks on you."

"Only if we could teleport away from this place. Somewhere more secluded." He looked at her playfully. "Then I'll be able to show you what my imagination is capable of."

"You're insufferable." She grumbled, but Peter saw the slight smile she was holding back.

He smirked. "Anything in the name of love."

"First of all ew, that's disgusting." Rocket informed them through the coms. This time Gamora laughed too. "Second of all, keep your eyes open. An unfriendly looking guy coming in."

"It's full of them here." Peter replied, glancing at the frowning men.

"Are they all not taking their hands off their pockets?" Rocket asked sarcastically. "Our friend is armed. Mantis, he's coming to you."

“Okay, what does he look like?” She asked.

"Bald head, black suit, nasty scar above the eyebrow."

"I saw him." She said. "He's talking to another man."

"He's not alone." Gamora noted.

"Leave them to me." Drax said.

"No, Drax, stay in position. We don't know how many accomplices they have." Peter said warningly. "I'll go to Mantis. If things get serious there, two more hands and a pair of other weapons won't be superfluous." He looked to his left at Gamora for approval, and when she nodded he stepped off the podium and made his way through the people.

Gamora followed his receding figure as his golden curls disappeared from her sight. She hated changes in plans. She and Peter had to guard the targets, and now she was left to handle it for herself. Well, at least she was surrounded by regular guards who would carry out any of her orders without question.

With her peripheral vision, she saw the man who had hired them as he approached her and stood to her right, where Peter was until five minutes ago.

When he said nothing, Gamora assumed she was expected to begin the conversation. She has been in diplomatic meetings before at the time when she was still completing Thanos' duties. It was not new for her to deal with business language. That is why she was the diplomatic face of the guardians. Peter and Rocket lit up way too quickly, and their primal instincts made

them agree to insane proposals. Drax was more civilized, but often could not understand some features of speech. And Mantis and Groot ... That wasn't exactly their field. "Nice party." She said.

"It's true, I kept myself busy for a couple of days but it was worth it." He answered proudly, but his next words were snowy. "Is there any reason to worry that its end will not be as good?"

A rhetorical question, Gamora thought. "I don't know, is there?"

"The fact that you were left alone on a on post by my side, mrs-."

"Miss." She fixed it. They both continued to stare at the crowd.

"My apologies." Tone, pretended to be nice but his next words were spoken with a voice, cold as ice."If your friend went to my daughter, money will be the last thing you see from me."

This caught Gamora unprepared. She turned her head behind them and really found that his daughter was gone. And from the look on his face, he wasn't happy about it. "Why do you think he would be with her? We're at work." *And he's fucking mine*.

"She spoke to me about him earlier." He looked at her for the first time, and one of his glassy eyes stared at her like a bullet. "And I'm aware of his reputation."

His reputation was something she tried to forget. The sight of him flirting with women other than her drove her crazy.

She shook off the thought. "This part of his life is in the past, I assure you." She said confidently. "The reason for his withdrawal was a precaution."

He raised his head. "Is there anything I need to know?"

"Two unidentified visitors." She replied. "Nothing we can't handle."

“Good.” He said and turned back.

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"I lost sight of them." Mantis said as Peter appeared beside her, waiting for information.

He widened his eyes. "How did you loose sight of them like that ?!"

" I do not know." She defended herself. "They were in that corner, then I looked at you, and when I turned around they were gone!"

Peter had no intention of yelling at her about it. Especially since he had done almost nothing tonight. "Okay, calm down, we'll find them. Rocket?"

"I don't see them." he replied.

“And the others?” Peter asked again.

"Nothing." Drax and Gamora replied.

Peter ran a hand over his neck, mumbling a "Damnit." It was true that he had low expectations for tonight, but they had just lost two possible killers, and if they were not found in the next ten minutes, this party would have turned into a bloodbath.

He left Mantis' side and walked slowly along the dance floor. He tried to look for suspicious faces in the audience, but he only ran into random guests who kept him from seeing from afar.

He had somehow reached the other end of the room. Mantis' antennas were nowhere to be seen, and when he tried to connect with others on the earbug, he found out that the music was too loud to distinguish the voice of anyone of them.

He found a light platform on which to step one head above the others. *That is something else.* He could see all the dancers in the center on the white marble floor and those who were too pretentious to have fun, so they stood in the corners. It all seemed right.

Until he saw a bald head that stood out from the rest. He waited for him to turn, and the brown scar crossing his eyebrow convinced him that this was the man they were looking for.

God, that really is a disgusting scar.

As Rocket had said, he kept his right hand in his pocket, probably holding a weapon. What worried Peter was the fact that the man kept his eyes on the dance floor. It was as if he were in a trance.

Peter tried to trace his gaze. And all he could say was. *Oh you've got to be kidding me*.

The daughter of the man who hired them danced in the center, unleashing her large dress as she spun. His eyes darted between their faces, not knowing what to do. Even if he told the others, they probably wouldn't hear him because of the noise around him.

Intuition led him quickly to the dance floor when he saw the girl finish dancing. She walked in the direction of the bald guy before Peter stood in her way, pale as a sail.

"Mr. Quill?" The girl raised an eyebrow, positive about her sudden visitor. "Can I help you with something?"

“Um - there weren’t many options. He couldn't take her out without arousing suspicion, and he couldn't warn her because her stupid father had told them she shouldn't find out what was happening. All that remained was the option of staying there and Peter interfering only if the other man took out a weapon. "Would you like to dance? I know you'd probably want a break, but-"

"With great pleasure." She smiled and took his hand, the other on his shoulder.

Peter also moved to the appropriate position. It was hard for him to admit it, but at that moment he didn't want to dance at all. Especially with a woman who wasn't Gamora. He was used to her slow pace. How she apologized every time she stepped on him, and he laughed at how charming she was. How in the middle of the dance she looked up at him and he sank into a trance in her eyes. Trapped in her body. And then there was a kiss for the finale. Or several. Okay, a lot. He loved those moments.

This was nothing like that. They were threatened by assassins whom only he knew where they were, and this girl was getting on his nerves.

"Is there another reason to invite me to the dance?" she asked interestedly.

He frowned. "No, I just love to dance." As they turned, he realized the man was gone. Panic gripped him. He had to warn the others. *But how could this happen?*

"Something wrong?" she asked.

"I have to find my teammates." he said, trying to pull away without using much force.

"I'm sure they'll be fine." She pulled him close and said in his ear. "In the meantime, we can have fun." Her seductive tone made him sick.

Alright that's it.

Peter took her hands and pushed her back. "Look, I don't know what impressions you got, but I have a girlfriend." He raised a finger to her. "If-"

His words were interrupted by a loud female scream. It sounded distant, but it was enough to silence the whole building. It was clear where the man was.

"Stay here." Peter told the girl.

He made his way quickly through the puzzled crowd. The music had stopped. There was a murky silence as Peter heard Mantis ask on the earbug."What happened?"

He finally reached the center of the event. A woman's body was thrown on the marble floor. Her orange blood ran down the white stone. " A murder." Peter replied.

It was as if the muffled sounds of gunfire echoed through the room on command. People started shouting on their way to the exits.

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Did he just invite that girl to the dance?

Gamora knew the mission. To stand on guard and look for enemies. None of this involved dancing. Especially with a girl who was obviously into him. *What if he heard her talk about it to her father? And he was interested?*

No. Stop. Not everyone is a traitor.

This was her Peter. The same one who hadn't looked at another woman since they met. The same one who told her stories from Earth, even though he didn't enjoy them, but he knew she liked to listen to them. The one who held her in his arms every night until she fell asleep. Who was by her side whenever she had nightmares. Who layed kisses on her lips and always made her feel better.

She had to trust him as much as her jealousy tried to prevail.

She felt her grip around her sword tightening as she made him an offer. She wanted to go and stick the head of that bitch on her blade.

She finally calmed down when he apparently rejected her, and it was as if even a faint smile could be seen on her face when he called her his girlfriend. They hadn't usually used words like boyfriend / girlfriend, although they were just that, maybe even more.

The smile faded from her face with lightning speed at the echo of the freezing scream from the next room. "What was that?" She asked, but received no answer.

She turned to the man who had hired them. He was on his feet and approached one of the guards, apparently for information. He looked as confused as she was. Then she heard Mantis ask, "What happened?"

As the guard whispered something, she heard Peter's voice clear as a brisket. "A murder."

Maybe three seconds later, two distant shots were heard. Gamora reached the guard quickly and turned him to face her, grabbing his arm roughly. "What's happening?"

"What do you think, they're attacking us!" He replied jagged and picked up his loaded machine gun, pointing it in random directions in an attempt to find the archers.

She turned and found that the millionaire and his wife were still there, hiding behind the table. She turned to the man again."Get them out of here. I can take it."

After staring for two seconds, he nodded resignedly and turned, leading the couple back, along with several other security guards.

She turned to the people. There were fewer left than before. Gamora guessed that everyone was heading for the exits. Better that way. Fewer people in her path.

She reached for her leather belt and wrapped her fingers around Her Godslayer's silver handle. Already on the verge of unleash it, the movement was halted by a sharp pain in her abdomen. Her hand automatically pressed against her, and when she moved it, blood ran down her fingers. She was shot. No, she couldn't have been so careless. How could she let her guard down? Before she knew it, another bullet went right next to her head and shattered a vase behind her.

Gamora would not wait for a third warning. She walked to the left, trying to connect with the others, but had the feeling that no one could hear her. She could tell they were arguing about something, but her head couldn't focus enough to know what.

All her attention was focused on was her bleeding wound. She touched her back. Nothing. No exit wound. Apparently the bullet was still in her, and she had to get it out. *Great*.

She had to hide, so she entered through the first door she layed her eyes on. The toilet. There were no tiles, it was the same as the floor in the halls. *God, this man loves white marble,* she thought.

She closed behind her and leaned against the huge sink. The green blood from her hands was smeared like a fingerprint. "Guys-" She tried again on the earbug. "Peter are you-"

And out of nowhere a rough hand wrapped itself around her neck. Another pressed a cloth soaked in an odor-familiar substance to her nose. *Intoxicating fluid.*

Damnit.

Gamora only managed to hit one of his arms, but not hard enough to have an effect. After she inhaled it, her body began to relax and her eyes rolled back. Her sword fell from her hand. Her powerless body lifted by unfamiliar hands.

Hidden Trouble

"Rocket?" Quill shouted, blasters pointing up.

"I see three shooters in my sector, but the shots are coming from more directions." Rocket replied.

"I knocked one over here." Drax said proudly.

"I don't see anyone." Called Mantis. Her voice showed that she was worried. In the few missions in which she took part, she was not left to cope alone in such a dangerous situation.

“Drax, go to Mantis!” Quill said.

Rocket was the first to object. "And leave the whole district free? There's no way!"

"You know we're not the only ones with weapons here?!" Peter shouted.

"Yes, otherwise we wouldn't have the problem of being shot at!" Exclaimed the racoon.

"I was talking about security!"

"I don't see any guards, Quill," Mantis said.

“What do you mean?” Quill asked confused, but looked around and really didn't see any other security. And after he stopped arguing with Rocket, he realized that the shots had stopped, too. It was quiet again, with the only difference being that there were no more

people too scared to speak.

The shooters were gone too apparently. " Where are they? "

"On the roof. They're getting out!" Rocket shouted.

Drax and Groot were already upstairs, chasing two of the invaders.

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Peter, Mantis, and Rocket met in the center of the hallway. "Okay, let's take a look, we can find some of them in my traps." Rocket suggested.

Mantis agreed. "Yes, we can. Gamora?"

When she asked Gamora, Peter realized that this was not the first time she had not been contacted. “Since when have you not contacted her?” He asked. Anxiety swept over him like a storm.

"Um, before the shootout started, I think l.” Rocket tried to remember.

"No, earlier." Mantis corrected him.

"I have a bad feeling." Shared Quill. "I'm going to the shelter, they must be there."

"I'll come too, we'll have a look at the traps later." Rocket said. They both looked at Mantis.

"You go, I'll catch up with you." Mantis said. A skeptical look fell on Peter's face and she looked slightly at the westroom.

"Be quick, let's not split up."

Mantis nodded and the two headed for the hiding place shown earlier. In such a scenario, the family had to be taken there by the security. Peter wondered if his daughter had made it there.

And why didn't they hear Gamora's voice for most of the mission? True, she was annoyed at times, and she preferred to remain neutral until the discussion was over, but he found it strange.
"Do you think Gamora may have turned off her earbug because we were arguing?" he asked Rocket.

"We didn't fight, Quill, it's how we talk and she's well aware of it." He replied. "It must be because of your flirtation with that chick."

"Wh-. You could hear it ?!" He replied in shock and hurried to defend himself. "That was not a flirt! I had to stand in the way of those guys!"

"You don't have to worry." Rocket told him suddenly with a rather Kinder voice." Probably another communication problem. If you're lucky, she wouldn't have heard you. "

"These problems have become common."

"Yes, if we had more units, we would get new earbuds."

"I'll remind you the next time you want the latest laser model."

Then Peter went silent again. And Rocket hated it. If he was gonna be down, at least it must have been his fault. "Gamora was in charge of the guards, she probably took them to safety. It's typical for her."

“To run away from battle?” He raised an eyebrow.

"To protect others." Rocket corrected him. Gamora stood behind his back more times than he had argued with Quill about playing music too early in the morning. And that was a number he could not keep track of.

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Finding the bunker was more difficult than expected. Not because it was so well hidden, but because apparently they were both not paying attention during the explanations.

After an additional five minutes of wandering, they finally reached a double-protected door with two guards in front of it.

"Identify yourself." One said.

"Peter Jason Quill, people call me -"

"Star-Much." Rocket finished for him.

Peter shot him a look, a vengeful smile on his face. "And that's my pet Rocket Raccoon."

Rocket growled in response, but before things escalated, the guard called again. "You can come in."

The door in front of them opened, surprisingly quiet given its size. Peter was the first to enter. A room much larger than an ordinary one. But given the rest of the building, it should come

as no surprise.

It looked like a modernized basement. Several tables in the middle and shelves on the walls, cluttered with supplies. A place prepared for an apocalypse.

The man, his wife, and surprisingly his daughter, were sitting at one of the tables. They quarreled before their attention was focused on the coming guardians. Peter would bet the girl was freaked out of the whole fiasco.

He scanned the room full of people for emerald skin. Unfortunately without success. "Where is Gamora?"

For a moment no one answered. Peter wondered if they didn't know where she was or if they just didn't recognize the name.

"She is not here." The security guard said, taking a few steps forward. "She told me to take them to the hideout while she dealt with the attackers."

Peter panicked. "There's no one outside."

"She could be on the roof if she started chasing them." Rocket guessed.

"She is not here." Drax's voice called through the transmitter."But we managed to catch one."

Quill felt his breathing quicken. His eyes raced between the others in the room, as if praying for someone to know what was happening to Gamora.

All right, all right. Don't think about the worst. Gamora is stronger and more capable in battles than anyone here. She's probably really tracked one of the attackers down another

path, or she's hiding somewhere waiting to be safe enough to return. "We have to look for her." Peter said resolutely.

"Um guys ..." Mantis's voice came nervously behind them. Peter hadn't even noticed the door open. He turned.

And suddenly his breath caught. Mantis stood before them with a horrified look in her eyes that perfectly reflected that of the two guardians. She was holding a sword. Not just any sword. Silver with several blades and engraved details. Gamora's Godslayer. With green blood flowing from the handle down.

Now you can start thinking of the worst.

Awake

Gamora awoke with a stern sense of cold. Nothing to do with the warm bed where she woke up next to Peter.

She tried to move her arms, but before she could open her eyes, she realized she couldn't move. She was in a sitting position. Leaning on the cold surface of a metal chair. Her arms and legs were cuffed tightly, tightening her limbs. A fifth noose around her neck kept her head upright.

She stirred cautiously to make sure she was still able to do so, but she was quickly reminded of the gunshot wound she had received. She hissed with narrowed eyes at the sudden pain.

She forced herself to take a few deep breaths through her nose, accepting the suffering. It was nothing new. Pain has always been a part of her life, one way or another.

She had to get strong. Strong for herself, because until recently there was no one worth fighting for. Before meeting the guardians.

Memories of Peter's voice came to her mind, telling her many times that he had never seen a stronger person.

When she was little, she thought that being strong meant never feeling pain. However, over time, she realized that *strong people experience the most pain. Understood it, accepted it and learned from it.*

'*Bad things always happen to good people*.'

"Life is unfair, little one." Thanos used to tell her. "There are no rules. There are no laws. So we have to make them ourselves."

She shuddered at Thanos's voice, still awake in her mind. She hated that voice. She hated him. She never wanted to hear his name again, as if erased from history.

"Daughter of Thanos!" An unfamiliar voice, ignoring her desire. She sighed and opened her eyes smoothly.

In front of her stood a chestnut man in his twenties. No one to recognize. "How do you feel?" he asked.

How she hated rhetorical questions. It took her out of her skin when the man in front of her pretended to be so witty.

"I guess so." He continued.

Gamora didn't say a word. She had no idea why she was being held there, but it was certainly not for sweet chatting. The less she says, the better.

For a few intense minutes, the two stared at each other. Gamora trying to figure out his intentions. Wide pupils, thirsty eyes. He looked at her like ... A predator. A predator trapping its prey, waiting for the moment to kill it.

It was nothing more. What would make a twenty-year-old boy kidnap an ex assassin? Popularity? Money? No, the way he looked at her, his chin down, his jaw trembling, the way his breathing deepened with each passing moment. This boy wanted revenge.

"I finally found you ..." Staring with hatred without even blinking. "After eleven years of persecution ..." Gamora tried to gather her thoughts and arrange the events until eleven years ago. But it was as if nothing in particular refreshed her thoughts. A fearful psychopathic smile appeared on his face, as if he did not believe what he saw.

“I can finally kill ya!” He approached her with a knife she didn’t even know he was holding. He rested the blade on the skin of her cleavage with abnormally wide eyes. "I can finally do this." He pressed the metal, spilling another of her blood. "And this!" New incision. "And this!" Each time said happier than before. "And even ..." The knife slid up her skin, reaching the bottom of her throat, just below the noose. He applied only light pressure to the skin, preparing to press before-

"Knife down." A new figure appeared behind the boy. Bald head and thick eyebrows with a rough scar running through one of them. Gamora immediately remmembered the description Rocket had given them at the party. "It doesn't make our guest feel comfortable."

Here is this irony again. Gamora gritted her teeth.

The man paced the room, back and forth in front of Gamora. "You must have a lot of questions ..." he began, but she didn't answer him. "Maybe 'Where am I?'. I can't answer that. But 'Why am I here?' it's something else. " He paused and stared into her chocolate eyes, which showed no sign of weakness or fear. "You're here to die." He said triumphantly, but her indignation made him pull away again.

"Then why am I still alive?"

He laughed at her audacity. "You're a big trouble, you know?" His head shook, shaking with thoughts he couldn't wait to bring to light. And Gamora would listen to his touching story, which made him so desperate. "This boy here, Axel found the bodies of his father and brother, along with those in half his town. My other friend, Rick, was defending us from Thanos' army. Before you and your siblings killed his friends, you left him crippled. "And I ..." He stepped forward. "I'm the man who fell to his knees in front of you, begging you not to kill my family."

He grabbed the handles of the chair aggressively, leaning inches from her face. "Do you remember them? Do you remember the face of my father, my mother, my brother ?!" Her stony expression infuriated him. Breathing like a rabid animal. The next moment he had stabbed another knife in her hand, eliciting a faint scream. "Do you ?!"

She took another breath And met his furious eyes once again.

"You will." He spoke again. "Before, I was the one begging for mercy. Now it's your turn."

Help

"What do you mean it was just lying in the toilet ?!"

"I don't know, there were bloody prints and-"

"Was there anything else to help us figure out what happened?" Peter asked again, almost shouting, but the others were not surprised considering the situation. He ran his fingers through his curls at Mantis's negative response.

Rocket turned to the guards with the idea, "There are cameras here, right?"

"Yes, several on each perimeter." The commander-in-chief replied.

"Wait, wait, wait." The expensively dressed man intervened. "These are *my* cameras! *My* property! You can't use them."

Quill's nerves approached the boiling point. "You're the one who hired us!" He pointed at him. "A member of my team is gone, if it weren't for you, it wouldn't have happened."

The man did not back down. "If you were standing next to her, instead of going down with my daughter, it wouldn't either."

And boil. Peter stepped up against him before the commander reacted and pulled him back. Peter wanted to get his blasters and make his complacency explode, but he knew that if he did Gamora wouldn't be the only one in trouble.

"We'll find her another way." Mantis turned to him.

"How ?!" Peter snapped at her. From her startled reaction, he knew he had raised his voice too much. He sighed, wanting to bring back the last few seconds. It wasn't her fault. "I'm sorry, Mantis. I-" He rubbed his hair again, as if trying to figure out where he was. It was like a nightmare. And Peter desperately wished it was. "I need air."

He shot out the door. He didn't even know how he got to the yard. A light rain gradually darkened his honey curls. Small drops falling on his cheeks like the tears, which he tried to suppress. A time that perfectly suited his mood.

"She'll be fine."

He looked in the direction of the familiar soft voice. Mantis stood beside him with a slight consoling smile.

He sighed, but smiled back sadly. "I'm sorry about that l. I had no right to-"

"It's okay. It's normal to be upset." She said, understanding. She didn't care that he lost his temper.

"I'm not upset, I'm just .." *What am I?* "Scared." *Of losing her too*.

"That's okay, too." She said encouragingly. "It means you care about her." Mantis paused. "I wish I had someone who cared so much about me." Peter then finally turned his head toward her. His eyebrows furrowed as he remembered that she had lived alone all her life. His insane father didn't count. "I've never had anyone."

He looked down. "We all share the same destiny, huh?"

"No, we share the same *past*."

In fact, he couldn't argue with that. Now they had the guardians. Each of them was on their own before, except Rocket and Groot, but now they had each other. Like in some old earthen song.
But the team was not complete now.

Rocket appeared and passed between them without stopping. "Let's get out of here."

"What? What about the cameras?" Peter exclaimed indignantly.

"I'll hack them off the ship. That loser will only help us if we pay him, and that will only happen over my corpse!" Rocket shouted as the others caught up with him.

“What about Drax and Groot?” Mantis asked.

"They will be waiting for us on the Milano. It's good that they managed to catch one of theirs. If we're lucky he'll tell us something."

“And if he doesn’t?” Mantis asked.

They both didn't answer her for a moment as Peter considered what to do. Indeed, their hostage could not speak. Then they could use him as a bargaining coin and exchange him for Gamora. But if he was not valuable to them at all? *Too many probabilities.*

They had reached the ship when Peter stopped. "You go in, I'll make a call and I'll be there in a sec."

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"Are you sure you can hack their system?" Quill asked unconvinced.

"Quill, we've been on the same team for four years, and you still doubt my skills?"

"No, but it is assumed that given their capabilities, their security system is-"

"Done." Rocket interrupted. He opened several windows showing the cameras in the different rooms."Okay, this is your hall." He zoomed in on five cameras centered in the room where Gamora and Peter were originally.

Quill leaned over and pointed to one of them. "This one ... Can you proceed?"

Rocket pressed a few buttons and the silhouettes on the screen sped up. Peter leaving.. the man who had hired them, talking to Gamora. Then she was left alone..

"Here!" Mantis exclaimed. "Now the shootout begins."

She was right. People panicing and a commotion. Gamora turned to the guard and he took the family away, as he had said. And Gamora is left alone ready for-

"Hold on, go back." Peter said. He traced the change in her position. "She was shot."

"That explains the blood." Rocket said. He traced where she was going. "She goes to the bathroom."

"Check who else comes in after her." Peter told him and Rocket, atypically for him, did what he was told. After all, it was his friend out there.

"No one." He said. "The only one who comes in after that is Mantis."

“And before that?” She asked.

Rocket turned the record back. No one stayed in the toilet. "That doesn't make sense." Peter said. "Someone came in. Gamora didn't come out the door, so they must have come out somehow else."

Apparently Rocket had an idea, because his little fingers moved quickly across the screen and opened a map. He followed it with his fingernail and sighed, "The ventilation shaft. That's how they came in and out without getting caught on camera."

Peter's head hung down. How could he allow this? As much as he didn't want to, his thoughts went back to that idiot's words. 'If you were standing next to her, instead of going down with my daughter, it wouldn't either.' And he hated how right he was. They didn't have to separate at all. He shouldn't have left her. He was cursing inwardly for this night.

Gamora was against solo work. She wanted them all in pairs, but Peter had dissuaded her. Now he understood why she cared so much. *God how can I be so stupid ?!*

His gaze rose as he heard Drax's heavy footsteps, approaching. He had been trying to find out something from the hostage for half an hour. "Something?" Peter asked hopefully.

"I'm sorry, my friend." Said Drax.

Peter couldn't stand his pitying look and looked at Mantis. Same expression.

"We can-" Mantis began, but was startled by the sound of a loud bang.

"What is this now?" Rocket turned.

Peter sighed and headed for the exit. "Plan B."

***

"What is she doing here ?!" Exclaimed the raccoon.

"Rocket, she can help us, she's better acquainted with Gamora's enemies." Peter explained.

"I don't care! What if she tries to kill us? Again! " He continued.

"I won't."

"And we should trust you because.. ?" Rocket asked.

"Because we have the same goal. My sister was kidnapped, I have no reason to sabotage you. I'm here to help. You were lucky I was in the same solar system when Quill called me."

Rocket grabbed his head. "Oh God!"

"Now come on." He said Nebula. "Take me to him. We don't know how much time we have."

That last sentence made an unpleasant feeling spread over Peter's body.

***

They took Nebula to the locked man. "This is him." Told her Mantis. "We managed to catch *him* only."

"That might be enough," Nebula said. She examined his robe. Black with gray hems. Her eyes focused on his badge. A symbol for grouping. She scanned it and searched her database.

"Do you know him?" Peter asked, looking at the projected shots.

She was quick to answer, even though she was busy. "No, but if I'm lucky I'll find out what group he belongs to."

"I bet he wants to use Gamora to kill Thanos." Drax thought.

Rocket was of a different opinion. "No, he looks to me like a desperate bastard in debt, and Gamora he will trade for a reward."

Peter frowned at both assumptions. *Do* t *they have to discussed this?* That was his girl they were talking about .. His girl who could be tortured at the moment. He turned to Nebula. "Can't it be faster?"

"No. I'm doing what I can, it doesn't help if you interrupt me." This made Peter look away at the hostage. Good thing it was Drax trying to get information out of him, because if it was him, the man would already have a few fractures.

"Cretaceous." Nebula said, finally showing footage to help. Judging by their expressions, it didn't mean anything to the others, so she continued. "Years ago, Thanos took over the Cretaceous planet. Gamora led the attack. Many people were killed, mostly by her hands. Her captors have apparently survived it, and the most likely reason for her abduction is for-."

"Revenge." Peter finished, realizing.

Nebula nodded. Chills on Peter's back. And not the one he got when Gamora kissed him. No, it was like an ice shower, making him tingle. If they were right, and the probability was terribly high, these people had no reason to keep her alive.

Meaning.. This whole thing.. The party, the shooting. It was all a cover. A cover for them to capture Gamora without anyone noticing it until they're gone. The millionaire wasn't the target. It was her. And they went right for it.

***

The Tracking

"What do you know about these guys?" Peter asked as everyone returned to the main quadrant.

"Not very much, unfortunately." Nebula began before Mantis spoke.

"But you've been there, right?"

"Yes, to kill them, not study them." Mantis looked down sadly. "I was captured by a Cretaceous. All I know is that they love torture. At least that's good news."

"Good news?" Peter exclaimed, as if he had heard wrong. "Are you kidding me ?!"

"It means we have more time to get her out of there before they kill her!" Nebula snapped. She saw Peter's horrified face after her words and realized how much he cared for her sister. Sympathy on her face and bitterness in her voice as she spoke. "They usually start with the limbs. Fingers, tongue, ears. Anything you can live without." It occurred to Peter to imagine him. "Then the arms, the legs-"

"Okay, no need for details, thanks." Rocket was disgusted.

"Basically everything we've been trained in." Nebula continued in summary. "Keeping the victim alive as long as possible to bear his punishment."

Peter grinned disgusted and shook the image in his head. "Okay, just tell me how much time we have."

"I don't know." The blue-skinned woman replied. "Depends on when they arrived."

"It happened about four hours ago." Drax informed her.

"So they may not have started yet, right?" Mantis asked with a hopeful smile.

"Yes." Nebula agreed. "At best, they haven't even arrived yet."

“How far is the Cretaceous?” Peter asked, and Rocket walked to the board to find out before Nebula stopped him.

"It won't help. The Cretaceous planet is already part of Thanos' possessions. Going there, the only thing we'll do is get ourselves killed."

“Who said you’re coming too?” The raccoon muttered.

"Rocket!" Quill stumbled, then softened his tone, glancing at the cyborg. "Then where's their group?"

" I do not know. "

Mantis was confused, "But you said you were captured, didn't you?"

Nebula sighed. "Yes, but the Cretaceous have five bases across the galaxy. We have no way of knowing where they took her."

“What if we call them?” Mantis suggested.

"We can't call them if we don't know whom." Drax pointed the obvious.

"Actually ..." Peter lit up, even with a slight smile on the edges of his lips. "We do know."

"What, did you sleep with anyone from there too?" Rocket laughed.

Peter shot him a gase but took a deep breath to hold his nerves. "We saw that guy at the party with a huge scar on his face. He was one of theirs."

"And how will we find him?" Mantis asked.

Nebula looked at the raccoon again. "You're the technician, right?"

"I prefer scientific genius."

Nebula rolled her eyes, irritated. "Hack their systems."

“All of them?” Peter looked at her skeptically.

"That way we'll get a list of members from each." Explained Nebula. "At least until we find the right person."

"She's right." Peter agreed. "Plus we don't have many options. Rocket, hack them."

Raccoon sat in front of the screen and began mumbling under his breath as he completed the task. "Rocket hack this, Rocket do that." He imitated with a grin face. "Rocket get me a new shampoo .."

“I’m never sending you for supplies again.” Peter approached to watch the process go on.

“Why, didn’t he get you a shampoo?” Mantis asked.

"Oh he got me. Pet shampoo!"

Rocket was indignant. "Hey, it was raccoon shampoo!"

"I know." Peter looked at him vengefully. Rocket just growled slightly in response and continued to work.

"Is that why you smelled so funny, Peter?" Mantis asked.

Rocket hissed at her, "What do you have against my shampoo?!"

Peter spoke to save Mantis from answering, "I couldn't get rid of the smell all week!"

"Wait, did you actually use it ?!" Rocket burst out laughing in his place. And Drax followed.

"That's why hair is a weakness," he said. "Quill, maybe you should follow my example."

Rocket's laughter intensified as he imagined Peter with Drax's haircut. Or..no haircut.

Nebula looked at them with her deathly serious expression. "How does my sister stand you at all?"

"Guys focus!" Peter shouted, and after Rocket resumed the decoding, he lowered his voice to Nebula. "We're not that bad." She raised an eyebrow and he continued. "At least it's not boring."

Nebula turned to the screen as Rocket called to them. "That's the one." He pointed to the man at the party, whom Peter recognized immediately.

"Which base is he from?" Mantis asked.

"I do not know." Rocket replied. "The groups are hidden under double protection."

"And you can't break it?" Nebula's tone rose angrily.

"It will take me a few hours."

Peter frowned. "We don't have that much."

For a while, the team stood still, some staring at the screen, others circling the room, trying to come up with a solution. An idea. Something.

"Maybe we should listen to Mantis." Suggested Drax. "Let's call them."

"Are you crazy ?!" Rocket shouted.

"Actually, why not?" Peter asked, considering the possibility. "It can help us to track them."

"First, *they* can follow *us*!" Rocket continued with the same nervous tone in his voice. "Second, we will lose the moment of surprise! They will know we are looking for them."

"They already know we're looking for them." Nebula opposes. "I actually share the opinion of the half-naked maniac."

Drax nodded gratefully, not paying attention to his new nickname.

"Let's vote." Mantis suggested.

"Fine." Peter said. "Who's for calling?" He asked, raising his hand at the same time. Nebula, Mantis, and Drax did the same. All eyes were on Rocket.

"I'm not taking the chances." he said.

"This is Gamora's life on the line!" He raised his voice, and this time he couldn't control his anger. "She might be dying right now, Rocket! If you have anything else in mind, be my guest!"

A tense silence reigned. Peter said what everyone thought, no matter how much they didn't want to believe it. They already knew she had been shot and was barely able to fight on her own to escape. They were her best shot.

Rocket took a deep breath. He knew Peter was right, and he turned to the monitor without objection, entering something as the others approached.

"Ready?" he asked.

Peter looked to his right. "Mantis?"

She nodded, ready to follow their signal.

"Do it." He turned to the raccoon.

A loading symbol appeared on the screen. Calling .. "No answer." Rocket said.

"Try again." Peter said. The raccoon listened to him. Again no success. There was no contact. He tried to reconnect. And again.

Peter got to his feet without waiting any longer. This was taking too long.

And then suddenly a picture appeared. Peter immediately went to Rocket again. Nebula also stood up to the person who appeared. "Vonor." She called him by his name.

The bald man narrowed his eyes to see who was standing on the other side, and a nasty smile appeared on his face. "Daughter of Thanos." He said. "May I know what caused this

extremely annoying ringing? Although I think I can already assume what the answer might be."

"My sister." She said firmly.

He narrowed his eyes. "So I thought." The man looked into the distance in front of him. "She's doing great for now. No screaming, no crying."

Son of a bitch! Who knows what condition she was in. Peter looked at Mantis and realized she needed more time. "Show her to us." He told him sternly.

The man on the other side frowned. He opened his mouth, obviously to refuse, but his eyes returned to Gamora. It took him a minute to think. But eventually spoke. "I guess a little emotional damage won't hurt ..." *It won't hurt for the torture*.

He moved the camera, and Nebula and Peter looked at each other anxiously, wondering what they would see. Rocket quickly thought of pressing a recording button on the screen.

"Gamora, dear, wanna say goodbye to your friends?" came from there, and Peter clenched his fists painfully. The man left the device firmly in place, backed away, and Peter stopped breathing with bated breath.

The sight of their chained teammate was revealed to the guardians. Knives stuck in both of her hands, her skin drenched in sweat and blood in places. The dark spot on her abdomen where she had been shot was even bigger. Her head tilted to the side as if she wasn't there at all.

She looked awful. And Peter's heart ached to keep watching.

The man next to her grabbed her face and turned it roughly toward the camera. Once her eyes focused on the monitor, they shone seeing her family's faces.

"Gamora -" She heard Peter's broken voice through the device. Gamora dared to open her mouth slightly in response, but the man next to her reacted immediately and twisted the blade that ran through her palm. She narrowed her eyes and hissed, leaning her head back.

"Whoa, Stop, Stop, No!" Peter joined again. "I just want to know she's okay!"

The bald man behind her nodded, giving a permission to the young boy beside her, and he stopped moving the sharp metal in her skin.

When she realized she was allowed to speak, Gamora forced herself to look at her friends again.

"I'm fine." She said.

Peter frowned even more when he heard how dry and husky her voice was. They probably didn't even give her water. But at least he made sure she still had a tongue.

"For now." The man behind her was stroking a curved knife with his fingers.

"I swear to God, if you hurt her-" Peter stepped forward furiously. "Your friend is deadman!"

The man didn't look particularly outraged. "He was slow anyway. Keep the bones if you want."

Peter blushed with rage. "Listen man, if my girl dies because of you, i swear to God, I'll come for you and your whole group of shits. I don't care what base you're on, I'll burn everyone to the last beam."

The man on the other side turned to Gamora again. "See? He doesn't even know where you are. You're screwed." He added with a satisfied smile.

Gamora raised her eyebrows in a mixture of frustration but sadness. That's what he wanted. That was part of the torture. *You break a warrior by breaking his will.*

"You son of a-"

"Fare well, whoever you are." The man said and the connection was lost.

Peter started pounding fists on the wall, furious. Mantis jumped at him. She knew he had to vent his anger, but she wanted to help him. "Peter, calm down."

"Calm down ?!" He snapped back. "Did you see her ?!"

"We'll get her out, my friend, have hope." Drax encouraged him.

"We couldn't track them!" He pointed out, seeing that there was nothing on the screen. "We're still at startpoint!"

"That might not be true." Nebula interrupted, thoughtful. Everyone looked at her expectantly. "Did you watch her eyes?" she asked.

“Yes, she could barely keep them open!” Peter pointed out angrily, not understanding her point.

"Not that." With that, Rocket quickly opened the recording he had made to find out what Nebula meant. "Good idea to record it, roden- .. Rocket." She corrected herself.

Seeing the love of his life in these circumstances again, Peter shook his head. "I can't watch it again."

"Hold on." Nebula told him and waited for part of the recording. "There. Get closer to her face." Rocket did just that, and she turned to Mantis. "Give me something to write."

Mantis handed her a notebook and a pen, and the blue-skinned woman immediately began to mark some symbols, keeping her eyes on the screen. She seemed particularly focused and confident in what she was writing, which was not the case with the others. They stared at her, then at Gamora, and their confused eyes tried to understand what was going on in Nebula's head.

At one point she looked down at the sheet, as if solving a complex equation. "Okay, will you finally tell us what's going on or-?"

"Her eyes. The way she blinked." She said without looking away from the writing. "The exact number and duration of the blinks matter. Once she saw that I was here, she used code that she knew I could figure out."

“Code?” Rocket asked, looking at the screen again.

"Something like the Morse code on Earth." She explained.

“What did she say?” Peter asked, trying to read what she had written.

"Wait." She said. Apparently ready, she stared confusedly at the sheet, "Rocket, check what you can find about Axen."

Raccoon took up the task and entered the name in a separate search machine. Several photos of a space station appeared on the screen. "Axen - the third intergalactic base of the Cretaceous nation." Read Rocket.

Peter widened his eyes and looked at Nebula to make sure he understood correctly. "She just gave us the location."

He looked back at her on the screen. He already knew where she was, and there was no one to stop him from getting her out of this hell. "Drax, enter the coordinates, we're leaving now."

The man nodded and left the room. As Peter followed, he felt a metal arm block his path, and he turned to face Nebula.

"That wasn't the only thing she said." Nebula said discreetly and handed the notebook to Quill. "I thought you should know." Then she left his side and went to Mantis and Rocket.

Peter looked down at the piece of paper in Nebula's curved handwriting. Symbols drawn above, probably in another language. Below, each of them was marked with a corresponding translation. The first-Axen.

And below it were a few words that Nebula has gathered in one sentence. Peter's heart pounded right there on that final line.

'Tell him that I love him.'

A Sign

Staying conscious was already extremely difficult. Her head was dizzy, and she wasn't sure if it was because of the blood she'd lost or the blows she'd suffered. She felt the fever, which showed that her body was struggling.

Gamora desperately wanted to sleep. Her eyelids begging her to close, at least for a moment. But she was aware of her condition. Even the slightest relaxation could not allow her to wake up again. Even though her species was much more durable and resilient than a normal person.

One of the reasons Thanos wanted so much to turn her into a warrior. She had once even heard him say in conversation that he was almost sorry he had killed her entire planet. ZenWhoberi would make excellent soldiers. That maybe he should have taken more children.

And then she imagined it. Watching not only Thanos torture Nebula for her sake, but also her friends with whom she shared a piece of bread. This was the subject of a number of new nightmares. It made her stop regretting that she was the last to survive. At least in these circumstances. No one deserved it. *'Don't feel sorry for the dead. Feel sorry for the living,* 'she was once told.

She sighed. As much as she didn't like it, she had to keep her brain busy. To abstract from the situation. And the best way was to awaken a feeling in her. Feeling strong enough to fill her veins with adrenaline and keep her sober. And the first one was anger. Anger at the man who abused her for years.

If it weren't for the guardians, she would probably still be serving that maniac, dreaming of something she's been told she doesn't deserve.

The guardians. They must be looking for her. They should have realized she wasn't here by now, right? *God I hope none of them got hurt on the mission. What if they kidnapped one of them too?* A wave of anxiety enveloped her. But then she looked at the two men through the glass window. *No, they want me.*

And then her bald tormentor appeared with a tablet-like device in his hand. *What, he's going to show his friends my execution?*

And then she saw them. She felt her heart beat even harder.. Peter, Rocket, Drax, probably Mantis and Groot were also out there .. Even .. Nebula. *God they even called Nebula.* Gamora knew how much Rocket and Drax were against her, but it was a fact that they worked together. Because of her.

Thank God her captors were stupid enough to leave visible signs on the screen that told her where she was. Considering the time, temperature, and the way people were dressed here, she

knew which station they were at. Gamora was well acquainted with the Cretaceous bases. They had been her personal tracking task before.
But Nebula didn't know them that well. Apparently that's why they're calling. Because they know the person, but not the location.

And then an idea came to her. A way to convey a message to them without speaking and to provoke more anger among the men.

Finally, a benefit from memorizing those symbols. All that remained was for Nebula to watch closely.

Action

Peter stood in the main quadrant throughout the trip. It wasn't long, for better or worse. Maybe an hour.

But he decided not to join the others and left his pilot's seat. He was sitting at one end of the cockpit, sitting in one seat. The same place where he had opened the gift from his mother.

This time, however, he was turning the piece of paper he had torn from the notebook in his hands. '*Tell him that I love him*.'

Not that he didn't know that anymore, just ... The fact that she wanted to tell him, however, made him think she was losing hope. That she wouldn't be able to tell him face to face.

He saw Nebula out of the corner of his eye passing through the cockpit. "Hey." He called to her.

She turned, but she looked confused, as if she wasn't sure he was talking to her.

"Thanks for what you're doing." He began, dragging her into conversation. "I know we're not exactly besties .."

"As I said. We have a common enemy." She sat across from him, watching him hold the sheet. "And more importantly, a common friend."

Peter took a moment to think. It's a fact that Nebula tried to kill Gamora several times, judging by the things she told him, but she was her sister. And since she responded immediately and was still here, she still cared about her. After all, "How do you handle this?"

Nebula shot him with a look of uncertainty. "Clarify the question."

"Well, she's your sister, well not a sister but ..."

She answered thoughtfully. "Blood is nothing Peter Quill. You should know it best of all."

Peter knew exactly what she was saying. Ego. He was his blood. But he was not his family. In fact, he was the reason part of it died. And now another part was in danger. "We'll get her out. The plan is good."

"I have to warn you ..." she told him after a pause. "If something goes wrong ... I'll choose her over you."

"Good. That's why I chose to go in with you." Peter replied.

***

"Alright time to go."

The guardians had already reached the station. They kept some distance so as not to be suspicious. If the Cretaceous noticed them, they would attack them. And probably kill Gamora if they haven't already.

Rocket had to stay on the Milano to guide the others. He had gotten rough drawings on the spot after he had time to break through their systems, and had access to some major locks, enough to pave the way for others.

Mantis and Groot would also stay because they were incapable of armed battle. Groot was still young, and a gunshot wound could affect his development. Mantis, on the other hand, was not trained to fight without using her powers. Although she had lessons with Gamora and Drax, she thought she would be more useful on the ship.

The others had to fly in protective suits to the base. The good news was that there were only three of them, which would be harder to spot. Especially with the help of Rocket. The bad thing was that if things got rough, they would be outnumbered. However, the Milano was close enough to hold the ball.

Once they reached the station, they parted. Drax stayed outside to guard as Peter and Nebula went inside, guided by the raccoon on the right path.

Peter tried to memorize the path to make his return easier. Over time, however, it turned out that the road was longer than expected and everything looked the same. Rocket told him the corridors were confusing, *but hell that place was a maze.*

"Stop!" Rocket called to them through the coms. "Guards are coming, back off!"

They hurried back, still careful not to make any noise.

"I thought you were going to take them on a road without guards." Mantis said, apparently to Rocket.

He didn't hesitate to answer hastily. "After all, this is a guarded lunatic fucking base, do you think there is a guardless road?!"

"Quiet!" Nebula whispered.

“We need direction, Rocket.” Peter said quietly, walking away from where they were supposed to go.

"Uhh ..." Rocket began scanning the cameras and the map in parallel. "There's no other way, wait there until the guards pass."

"We're exposed!" Nebula hissed, looking around for danger. "We have to move!"

"Otherwise you start an open fire." Peter turned to her. "You won't be very useful dead."

Nebula disagreed, but bit her tongue and fell silent until they received permission from Rocket to continue.

They heard the retreating footsteps of the guards they passed. Peter moved forward with his hand on the blaster, instinctively. Their plan did not include shelling and attracting the attention of the entire station, but in their cases the plans were only initial ideas.

Two more steps, and Peter jerked back, pushing Nebula. "Back, back, back."

"There's no back!" Nebula hissed.

"Rocket?"

"More guards have appeared." He announced.

"You don't say!" Peter snapped quietly.

"Let's kill'em!" Nebula said, unleashing her sword.

"Stay there! Weapons down!" And suddenly behind them a dozen armed men. The two were stunned, at first reaching for an attack, before an almost as large group appeared behind them, their rifles raised.

Damnit!

There was no way they could win a direct battle. Peter and Nebula only looked at each other, hoping that at least one had a better idea than to surrender. Then back to the person who repeated. "Weapons down!"

And then only Rocket's voice rang in their heads. "Run!"

No second thought. The two of them ran down the corridor that crossed the previous one. Unfortunately in different directions.

Orbs of energy and bullets flew in both directions. Nebula was faster and easily outrun the guards. However, this did not apply to Peter, who did not even know where he was. It was all happening too fast for Rocket to orient him properly. "For God sake Quill, just hide somewhere!" Shouted the raccoon.

Peter took a few more turns. He felt he was going even deeper. Walls everywhere. Walls, walls and more walls. "Oh!" *And more guards. Great*!

Another turn, and he finally found a door that didn't have an ID card lock. Metal and heavy, but what was that before the will to survive.

A second later he was in a small room, trying to catch his breath.

"You two okay?" The raccoon asked.

"Yea ..." Peter barely replied.

"I'm good." Nebula answered quickly, as if she had never run away. *Well that's not fair*, Peter thought.

"Okay let's -"

And boom. A loud and annoying alarm sounded all over the place, and some of the lights began to flash red. *Complete package*. "What the hell?" Peter covered his ears with his hands. To silence the alarm and perhaps hear Rocket's annoyed voice.

"What are you complaining about, the alarm went off because of you two!" Rocket shouted.

"We?" Peter shouted, too, because he was sure no one would hear him at that noise. "You had to guide us!"

"Not now!" Reminded them Mantis.

And then Nebula's harsh voice. "Free Gamora *now*! If they know we're here, they'll kill her!"

"She's right! Look!" Mantis called and pointed to Rocket at the camera from Gamora's cell he had opened.

Rocket began to type something as Peter asked. "Look what?"

"Rocket, quicker!" Mantis's frightened voice drove him crazy. *What the hell was going on with this camera ?!*

"Almost ..." Rocket was so close. "Done!"

Peter rested before hearing Mantis's voice hitched. "What?" No answer .. "Guys! What is it ?!" And all of a sudden it all stopped to him. No alarm. No light. No other people. He didn't seem to see clearly. It was as if he felt nothing. Nothing but panic.

Is Gamora -..?

Darkness

Gray walls blending. The hot blood drying on her clothes, making them hard as rock. Her hands were lifeless, no longer even trembling as the knives in her hands moved. That was part of the lesson, right? *Accepting the pain*. So much so that you stop paying attention to it.

Gamora stared at a spot on the wall. A miniature hole through which three ants resembled. She watched them with hatred. How they got to move freely without anyone telling them anything, and she couldn't even shake a finger without getting a target on her back. Wherever she went. Whatever she did.

'This is who we are. You can't run from it. It will hunt you down. ' Another lesson from another trainer.

And here she is again. Locked in a cell. Shackled to the neck. Without a way out. *Maybe Nebula didn't find her message in the end*. Maybe it was a well-deserved punishment. If that was her fate, it-

The alarm rang. The lights changed. *A sign*.

- It definitely had other plans for her.

Although she did not know what had happened, the premonition led her to believe that this signal was for her. *Time to fight*.

And just then the bald man went through the door, rushing towards her. He lunged at her and grabbed her by the throat. His other hand abruptly pulled one of the knives from her right hand. "Is that them?" he asked her. When he didn't get an answer, the knife wrapped around the gunshot wound to her abdomen and she shut her eyes closed. His grip around her neck even tighter while he shoke it, growling in her face. "Is that them?!"

She couldn't catch her breath. He was suffocating her. She felt her whole body tensing in an attempt to do something. But it was shackled.

Until there was a faint click against the background of all the noise. The man didn't hear it, but she felt her limbs had more room to move.

Waste no time. Gamora kicked him in the groin with her knee, and he writhed in pain. Another blow, but this time to repel him.

However, as she stood up, Gamora also frowned at the sharp pain in her abdomen and so she was caught off guard when the man walked over to her and slammed her into the edge of the chair.

New wound, new blood. This time from the top of her forehead. And then she was pushed on the floor. That cold filthy floor.

That was when she actually realized how weak she was. Blood loss, dehydration, fever. She was far too weak to stand up. Her body was ready to give up. *Traitor!*

She felt the footsteps, heavy to her ear. He squatted down to get a better view of the situation. "Time to face the consequences of your actions, daughter of Thanos."

He raised a dagger over her head, ready to break it in two.

No this can't be it.

'*There will always be people trying to kill you .. The question is, will you let them? "*

She opened her eyes. Her hand reached for one of the fallen knives, covered in her dark green blood. She grabbed it and stabbed the man in the ankle. Then she twisted painfully, and before the man knew it, the knife had crashed into his skull. "Like hell I will." She mumbled before she took out the blade.

His lifeless body collapsed on the floor. And she next to him, leaning on one elbow, trying to find the strength to stand up.

And a new click. This time from the direction of the door. She unlocked itself. Just on time. But how-?

And then her gaze darted to the camera. *Oh they definitely got the message*. They were here.

Means she had to find them.

She picked up the knife from the ground and stood, slightly unbalanced. Her hands rested on the door and then pressed the handle. Then the other.

Three tunnels opened in front of her. Where was she expected to go? Nothing could be seen. Nothing but flashing lights. All migrating in red. All but the right. There the lights were dimmer.

There was not much choice anyway. She walked down the right corridor, her hand gripping her wound.

She had no idea where she was going.

Her head was too disoriented to navigate her in a place she didn't know, and she didn't have time to stop to read the little signs on the walls.

Turn after turn.

Her pace quickened when voices were heard. Too difficult to determine from where.

She had a feeling they were getting closer. The thud of their footsteps.

The voice in her head screaming: *Run*!

The pain swept over her body as her legs quickened. '*Run for your life.'*

She looked back to see if anyone was behind her when she felt two strong hands pull her aside. She got déjà vu from the party.

Instinct first. She raised a knife at her unknown assailant, though she saw nothing where he locked her up. He took her hand quickly enough to protect himself.

"Hey, hey, it's me!"

Confused, she lowered the strength in her hand and the man cupped her face, approaching so she could focus his face. "Peter ..." she said, as if wondering if she was dreaming. He nodded with a slight smile. His eyes stared at her as if they couldn't believe she was in front of them. Those beautiful green eyes. "Peter!" She smiled with relief and wrapped her arms around his neck. He didn't back down and hugged her around the waist. Her head resting on his shoulder.

The voices on the outside of the door made them pull away. Gamora leaned against the wall behind her, feeling dizzy again. Peter wouldn't let go of her waist, being careful not to hurt her further. "Hey look at me, we're getting out of here." Her eyes stared lazily at his. "I have a plan."

"Please tell me it's more than twelve percent."

He found himself chuckle and leaned forward, placing a kiss on her forehead. Then he pressed his com with his finger. "Rocket, I need you to drill a hole in the base to distract the guards, but it must be away from us."

"Finally to the point." Rocket said amused.

Peter continued. "Mintis, you will have to guide us and Nebula on the road when the guards are gone."

“Okay!” Said Mantis.

"Once we're out we get Drax and fly back to the Milano. Everything clear?" It's true that Peter said he had a plan, but he made it up right now.

As soon as they heard Rocket's shooting, Mantis instructed them which way to go. "Let me carry you." Peter said.

Gamora, of course, was too stubborn to agree. "You're going to get tired too fast. I can walk."

He would keep insisting, but he knew that arguing with Gamora was not good. He sighed. "Okay, at least lean on me."

As much as she wanted to prove to him that she could do it alone, she knew that was not the case. She wrapped her arm around his neck, allowing him to be her support.

"Alright Gamora, Peter, go now. We don't know how long it will be clean." Mantis said.

They wasted no more time. They were listening to instructions, at least Peter was, and they were moving surprisingly fast.

However, Gamora was already bending. "How much more?" She asked, her eyes half open.

"Mantis?" Peter asked, and when he received an answer, he told her. "Very little. Hold on."

Easy to say. Yes, Gamora had survived worse, but she hadn't been in so much physical pain in a long time since she didn't have to endure Thanos' punishment. If it weren't for the

adrenaline rush, her body would have completely given up.

"Soldiers are approaching Peter behind you! At this rate, you will not be able to arrive on time." Mantis shouted.

This time he was really about to pick her up, but they would still be slow. There was no way they could get there together. "Gamora," he put his hand on her cheek. "Gamora, listen to me, I need you to go to the left." He could see how weak she was, but he had no choice. "Once you get to the exit, Drax will be waiting for you on the other side."

"W-What about you?"

"I'll slow down the guards." She shook her head in disagreement. She did not want them to be separated. Again. Neither did he. "Go. There's no time."

He gently lowered her hands and held them, giving her the courage to continue on her own until he finally released her and she turned reluctantly. Peter watched as she leaned against the left wall. A blood trail behind her fingers.

And here they are at last. Security Guard after Security Guard. Peter started firing at each one with unprecedented hatred. But he hadn't noticed those coming from behind. He didn't do it until he felt a burning sensation in his shoulder.

He turned back, leaving another to hit him lightly in the thigh. He hissed and raised a weapon at him only to see that his head was missing. A sharp sword swung in directions, and as Peter saw the blue skin, he recognized his teammate.

He dealt with the other half of the guards. Apparently they weren't used to the shooting, because no one could hit a single target. Although he didn't make it any easier with his agility.

When he thought that everything was getting better, he heard a woman's groan on his left side. He looked at Nebula, who had been knocked to the ground. Aiming his blaster at her, he left his guard down. In a second he was on the floor as well.

The two fell down looked at each other. *How the hell they allowed themselves to be brought down on the ground?* It was acceptable to him, but Nebula? She was probably hit too.

Already at gunpoint, Peter covered his face with his hands, wanting to keep his face untouched. Already prepared for the blow, he heard the shot, but his hands were not yet fried. He moved them away only to see the guard's falling body.

New shot. Looking ahead, Peter was speechless. Gamora, leaning against the wall, barely able to stand on her feet, firing with a machine gun at the others. Apparently she also came across security guards and took the weapon from them.

This gave both him and Nebula an advantage. Soon they were both on their feet, finishing the other guards.

Gamora could stop for a while. Her head leaned against the wall. She felt the adrenaline rush out of her body. She felt weightless. It was as if no part of her body could move anymore. As if she was paralyzed. Without control. The only thing she felt was falling. Her body slid down.. and fell right into Peter's arms.

He picked her up and hurried to the exit, with Nebula beside them, watching for unexpected jumpscares.

Gamora was watching him from below. She saw how dirty his favorite leather jacket had become. Green blood soaking in. "I'm ruining your jacket." She said still in a somewhat dry voice.

"It was never my favorite anyway." Peter said, trying to cheer up the serious situation. To make her feel better. *As always*.

"I love you." She said, closing her eyes.

Her body was relaxed in his arms. Lifeless. Her eyes closed. "Babe? Hey, stay with me." Gamora showed no reaction. "Gamora, please. Don't close your eyes. Please. We're almost there."

Unconsciously, he quickened his pace. Nebula too. Gamora was loosing it. Everything was merging. Peter's words grew more and more distant. As in a dream. Or a nightmare. She needed rest. She couldn't keep fighting her body.

“I can’t.” She whispered before the darkness engulfed her.

Safe

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Gamora had been healed at the Xandar's hospital for several days already. It was the safest place, as they sometimes worked with the New Corps. One of the few organizations that did not try to kill them.

Most of the guardians stood on the ship and visited it regularly. All but Peter. He hadn't even left.

He had pulled a chair next to her hospital bed and was not moving. In cases where he needed to leave, he called one of the other guardians to replace him. During her first few days in the hospital, her condition had suddenly worsened several times. After Peter was about to have a panic attack, he no longer wanted to risk leaving her alone.

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Peter considered what to do when they returned to the ship. The doctors had told him Gamora was getting better and should wake up soon. He listed all the movies she had told him she liked. He would play them in their room and cook something to eat together while watching them. No, he wouldn't, he wasn't gonna separate from her for a moment. *Drax would cook it! No, Drax can't cook. Mantis then!*

And her favorite books! He had to think of picking one up for when she woke up. Maybe Rocket could-.

The movement of the door drove him out of his thoughts. At first he thought it was one of the doctors, but ... Nebula?

This was the first time she'd actually been inside this room. Otherwise she was standing outside, looking at Gamora through the glass window.

She went in and stared at her sister, leaning against the wall with her arms crossed. For a while, neither of them said anything. Nebula looked so .. She was lost in thought. After a few minutes, she spoke.

"She looks so ... peaceful."

Yea, she did. Such a contrast compared to what had happened. But Peter preferred to see her that way. Calm. After everything she's been through.

"Ironic, isn't it?" He caught her attention. "We went to save her, and in the end she saved us." He stumbled upon this thought.

Nebula lifted her chin. "She's strong."

He remembered the times Gamora had told him that Thanos had made them compare. And that Nebula has always been underestimated. He felt a little compassion for her at that moment. "And you're not for underestimating." But he had to ask her something that tickled his mind. "You said that if things went wrong, you would choose Gamora over me. Why didn't you go after her but came to help me?"

"I didn't know she was still inside. She should have been with Drax by then." She paused, but Peter knew that wasn't all. "She was still on my side, even when I tried to kill her on Knowhere. If I had let you die, she would have never forgiven me." *So there was a person behind that rough personality, he thought*. "I'm trying to make things better."

"Well I think it's working. I mean, if it weren't for you, we wouldn't be able to do it. Consider it a victory " She looked at him thoughtfully. "Do you know why else it's a victory?" "You and I haven't had any fight yet. It's almost hard to imagine."

She looked at him deadly. "I would not rush with the conclusions."

A faint smile on his face. "So kind of you. I guess it's a family thing."

Her expression was still stern. "If something like this happens to my sister again, I'll gut you alive. And I'll make it's painful."

"It will not happen. I am the best guardian in the galaxy." He replied with a contented dose of confidence.

"Don't force your luck." She said, but before Peter could respond with another biting comment-.

"Mm .. What a nice waking-up."

They both stared at the bed. Peter's face glowed when he finally saw Gamora's eyes open. "Good morning, beautiful."

She smiled. What a gorgeous view. Excluding the hospital bed.

“How are you feeling?” Nebula asked her.

"Compared to last time, much better." She replied.

"Good." Nebula replied. Seeing Gamora and Peter in front of her, she felt out of place. "I'll be outside." Peter nodded and she turned.

"Nebula-" She turned back to Gamora's voice. "Thank you."

Then something in Nebula's expression softened. Peter could have sworn he saw her smiling. Then she nodded, as if she fulfilled done her duty, and left.

Peter turned his full attention back to Gamora. He was still sitting next to her. He would hold her hand all the time, but he wanted to be careful with the wounds on her hands.

Peter didn't take the smile off his face, while he asked her out of curiosity. "Did you hear the whole conversation?"

"No." She gave him a light smirk. "Just the most of it." He chuckled. "How long have I been unconscious?"

"One week." A pure look of surprise upon her eyes. "The doctors said you were getting better. I think we can be back at Milano in a few days."

She frowned in displeasure. "I don't want to spend that much time here. I hate hospitals."

"Neither do I, but I won't risk taking you home where we don't have the medicine we need and making your condition worse."

"Cuddling with you would help me a lot more than some drugs." She said in a slightly offended tone that Peter found adorable in this context.

"Who said we can't do it here?" He asked. Gamora seemed to like the idea because she immediately tried to move aside to make room for him before he stopped her. "Sh, no moving." He said explicitly.

Peter didn't need much space. At least not for his whole body. He layed next to her with one foot still in the air and helped her to lean on his arm. Her head rested on his shoulder. He felt her body relax as he wrapped his arm around her.

But there was something about his conscience, and he knew he had to tell her if he didn't want it to keep harassing him. "I'm sorry."

"What for?"

"For leaving you alone." Gamora tilted her head to look at him. "If I had stayed you-"

"Hey." Her bandaged hand slid over his chin. "You did what you thought was right."

"But-"

"No" she said softly. "You had no way of knowing it was going to happen." Her fingers continued to tickle his skin. "Besides, you came for me."

"Yea." He said, a smile appearing on his face. "Thank God you have such a caring boyfriend."

She rolled her eyes, but she found herself smiling too. *That's my arrogant Star Lord.*

"Mm my hero." She mumbled ironically, but she really meant it. He was her hero. First saved her from Thanos. Then on Knowhere. And now this. He was beside her like no one else has been. The only man who made her reveal herself to him.

"What you did there was very stupid thought, you know that?" He spoke again. Gamora looked at him, not understanding.

"You returning to the fight," he explained. "It was dangerous. You could have gotten hurt even more."

A smile appeared on her face. "*Anything in the name of love,* right?"

He couldn't help but smile back at the way she used his own words.

Then the memory of the base came to his mind as he carried her in his arms to the exit. '*I love you,*' she had said.

He looked down at her. Her chocolate eyes, staring at him with the same spark as before. As if he was all she had.

She was all he had. He placed his hand on her side, stroking her cheek with his thumb. "I love you too."

And he kissed her soft lips.

A sweet, loving kiss. That was it. That was all he wanted. Her. In his arms. Safe.

It was all finally over now.

Chapter End Notes

The story is finally done, I planned on doing around five chapters at first, but I think it came out pretty well like that.

Thank you for reading!

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!